public's trust. Shortly after the *Courante uyt Italien, Duytslandt &c*. appeared, a competing newspaper titled *Tijdinghen uyt Verscheyde Quartieren* (Tidings from Various Quarters) made its debut. The *Courante* was generally considered more reliable, because it tried to check its stories before publishing them, and because the *Tijdinghen* was accused of being overly patriotic and reporting only news favourable to the Netherlands. Nevertheless, both newspapers survived, because, as one reader explained, 'one can always find something in one newspaper that is not available in the other'. In the following decades dozens of additional newspapers were published in the Netherlands, which became Europe's journalistic hub.[43]

Newspapers that succeeded in gaining widespread trust became the architects and mouthpieces of public opinion. They created a far more informed and engaged public, which changed the nature of politics, first in the Netherlands and later around the world.[44] The political influence of newspapers was so crucial that newspaper editors often became political leaders. Jean-Paul Marat rose to power in revolutionary France by founding and editing *L'Ami du Peuple*; Eduard Bernstein helped create Germany's Social Democratic Party by editing *Der Sozialdemokrat*; Vladimir Lenin's most important position before becoming Soviet dictator was editor of *Iskra*; and Benito Mussolini rose to fame first as a socialist journalist in *Avanti!* and later as founder and editor of the firebrand right-wing paper *Il Popolo d'Italia*.

Newspapers played a crucial role in the formation of early modern democracies like the United Provinces in the Low Countries, the United Kingdom in the British Isles, and the United States in North America. As the names themselves indicate, these were not city-states like ancient Athens and Rome but amalgams of different regions glued together in part by this new information technology. For example, when on 6 December 1825, President John Quincy Adams gave his First Annual Message to the US Congress, the text of the address and summaries of the main points were published over the next weeks by newspapers from Boston to New Orleans. (At the time, hundreds of newspapers and magazines were being published in the United States.[45] )

Adams declared his administration's intentions of initiating numerous federal projects ranging from the construction of roads to the founding of an astronomical observatory, which he poetically named 'light-house of the skies'. His speech ignited a fierce public debate, much of it conducted in